

Afterword

The power of climbing is awesome. The simple act of moving over stone can change your day, and it can change your life. Climbing takes you to places you have never been before—breathtaking vistas that few humans ever see, and deep into the very core of your being. In this way climbing helps us discover who we are and gives us the gift of insight into our true potential and what really is possible in our lives. Many “flatlanders” never gain this insight, and, worse yet, far too many people around the world will never have the opportunity to experience the wonder of climbing (or any other pleasure-seeking activity) because they spend each day of their life just trying to get by. From this perspective I trust you will agree that in simply being able to go climbing and pursue self-actualization, we are better off than the majority of people on

this planet. Regardless of your current disposition, vow to live each day with an attitude of gratitude. Look for ways to brighten the day of everyone you meet, and consider contributing some time or money to aid those who are less fortunate. I invite you to check out some of my favorite charities listed below. Share some of your climbing power with the world!

- Paradoxsports.org
- EscalandoFronteras.org
- SharmaFund.org
- MakeAWish.org
- WoundedWarriorProject.org
- RedCross.org
- WorldVision.org

Appendix A

Muscular Anatomy





Appendix B

Training Charts

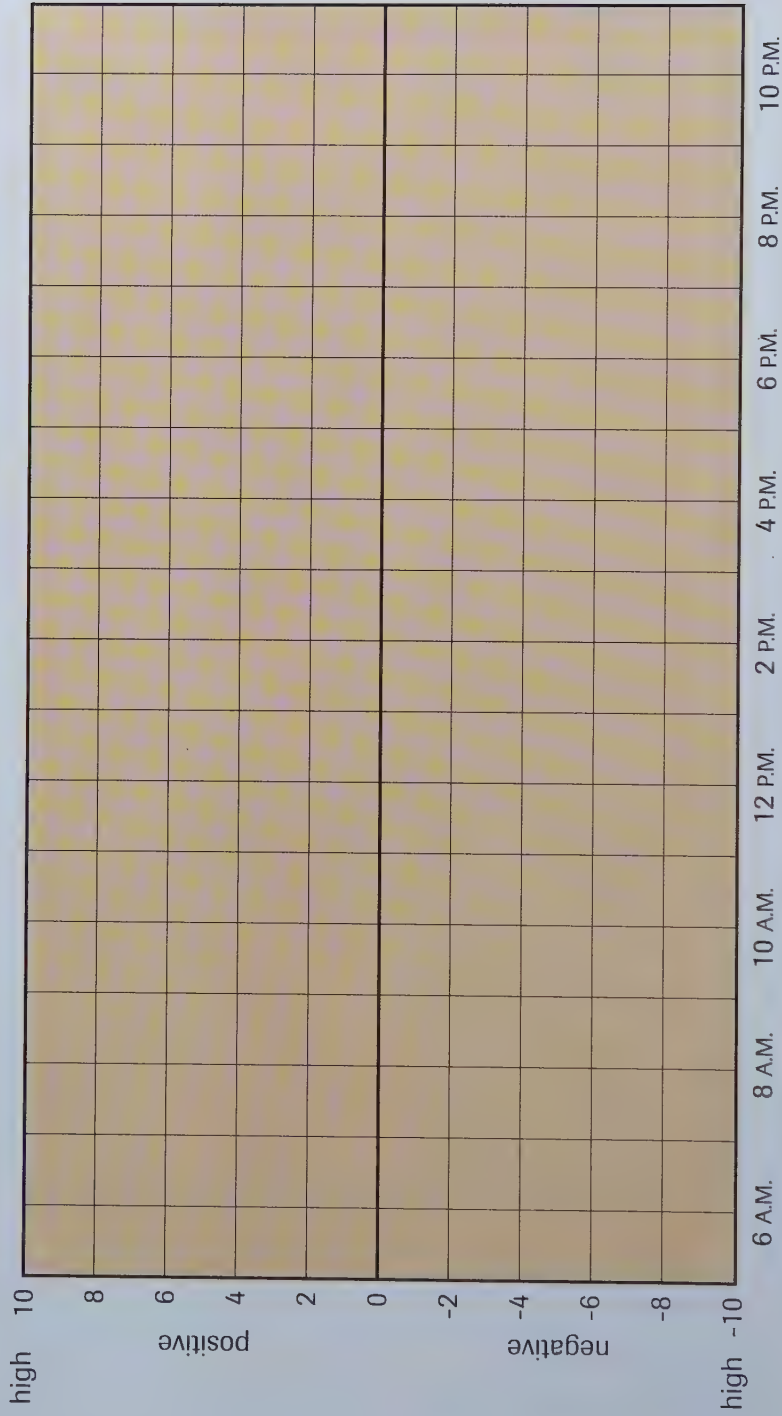
Use the two blank training charts on the following pages to track your training progress. The “Training and Climbing Macrocycle” will enable you to set annual training objectives and seasonal climbing goals as well as record your actual progress. You can use the chart to plan your training for the four seasons, target specific types of training, track the number of days you train, and record your achievements throughout the year.

Use the “Energy–Emotion Levels” chart to track your physical energy and emotional mind-set hour by hour throughout the day. You can use this chart to observe patterns, identify negative triggers, modify your emotional state, and better manage your energy and emotions for optimal performance.

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Appendix C

Self-Assessment Test Comments and Training Tips

The Self-Assessment Test in chapter 2 covers physical strength, mental focus, and techniques and tactics. Taking the test should help you to gauge your overall strengths and weaknesses and pinpoint some specific areas for improvement. If you gave yourself a score of 3 or lower on any of the questions, you've identified weak spots that should be targeted for training. Here is a brief comment on each of these common problems as well as some specific tips for improving your climbing performance. For more in-depth information on any of these topics, see the chapters referenced below.

1. If your footwork deteriorates during the hardest part of the climb, you might be focusing on the lack of good handholds instead of zeroing in on crucial footholds (often the key to unlocking hard sequences).

TIP: When the going gets tough, focus on your feet! (See chapter 3.)

2. If your forearms balloon and your grip begins to fail, you are probably overgripping the holds and/or climbing too slowly.

TIP: On near-vertical walls, relax your grip and place maximum weight over your feet. When the wall angle is overhanging, the number one rule is to climb fast from one rest to the next. (See chapter 4.)

3. If you have difficulty stepping onto critical footholds during hard sequences, lack of flexibility or weak hip flexor muscles is the likely problem.

TIP: Begin daily stretching for a minimum of ten minutes and practice high steps in a gym setting. (See chapter 6.)

4. If you find you get anxious and tight as you head into crux sequences, normalizing your breathing is the key to reducing tension and anxiety.

TIP: Before starting up a climb, close your eyes and take five slow, deep breaths (each breath should take at least ten seconds). Try to maintain steady breathing as you climb. Take three more slow, deep breaths at each rest position and before you begin the crux sequence. (See chapter 3.)

5. If your biceps pump out before your forearms, it usually means you're hanging out with bent arms. Straight-arm positions are fundamental to good climbing technique.

TIP: Whenever possible, hang "by the bone" and not with flexed arm muscles. Straight-arm positions are especially important when placing gear, shaking out, or pausing to decipher the next sequence (see chapter 4).

6. Do you have difficulty hanging on to small, necessary holds? Although poor body positioning can make small holds even harder to use, it's likely that your contact strength (grip) needs work.

TIP: Spend more time training on steep walls and gym cave areas, and go bouldering more often. Some weighted fingerboard training is essential for intermediate and advanced climbers. (See chapter 8.)

7. If you fail on sequences you know by heart, you might be making the common mistake of trying or inventing new sequences during a redpoint attempt.

- TIP:** When you find a sequence that works, it's usually best to stick with it. Counter any mid-climb thoughts of trying a new sequence with the definitive belief that you already know (and can do) the best sequence.
8. If you stall at the start of crux sequences, you might be suffering from paralysis by analysis.
TIP: When faced with a crux sequence, visualize two possible sequences, and then immediately try the one that looks more promising. Once you commit to a sequence, go for it! Only one thing should be on your mind—getting to the next good hold (or rest) as fast as possible.
 9. Do you climb three or four days in a row?
Unless you are one of those genetically gifted extreme outliers, climbing or training on three or four consecutive days is a practice that will lead to overtraining, injury, and a drop in performance.
TIP: In this case, less is more. Switch to a two-day-on, one-day-off (or one-day-on, one-day-off) schedule and you will be training smarter and climbing harder!
 10. Sewing-machine leg is common in the tight, anxious climber.
TIP: Lengthen your warm-up and begin working on some of the relaxation exercises described in this text. (See chapter 3.)
 11. If you pump out on overhanging climbs, you should be aware that the pump clock starts running when you leave the ground. You might not be too weak to climb the route—just too slow!
TIP: Practice climbing more quickly on known (wired) routes and when redpointing. Foster a watchful eye that's on the lookout for creative rests that might stop the clock for a few moments. (See chapters 3 and 4.)
 12. Do you get out of breath when you climb?
Rapid breathing while climbing results from excess tension, irregular breathing, or poor aerobic fitness.
TIP: Concentrate on maintaining relaxed, normal breathing while you climb. Also consider engaging in some aerobic training (preferably running) three to four days per week. Build up to a maximum of four, twenty-minute runs per week. (See chapter 7.)
 13. If you begin thinking about how you might fail on a route before you even start, you should know that belief gives birth to reality. If the thought of failing crosses your mind, you likely will.
TIP: Before you start up a climb, always visualize yourself successfully climbing the route from bottom to top. (See chapter 3.)
 14. Do you miss hidden holds on routes? Tunnel vision is a common cause of failure, especially during on-sight climbing.
TIP: Scope the route from a few different vantage points before leaving the ground. As you climb, keep an open mind for hidden holds—the key hold always seems to take a little extra effort to locate. If a route feels really hard for its grade, chances are there's a good handhold or foothold escaping your view. (See chapters 3 and 4.)
 15. If you have difficulty hanging on to small holds or pockets, keep in mind that open-hand grip strength is crucial. Expert climbers favor it, while beginner climbers avoid it.
TIP: While training and bouldering, force yourself to use the open-hand grip at least 50 percent of the time. Most intermediate and advanced climbers can significantly improve open-hand grip strength via weighted fingerboard hangs and campus training. (See chapter 8.)

16. It's common to grab onto gear rather than risk a fall trying a hard move. Assuming the potential fall is safe, always go for the move instead of grabbing gear or hanging on the rope. The bad habit of grabbing gear is easy to develop and very hard to break. Plus, you'll never learn where your true limit is if you give up in this way.

TIP: Counter any thought of grabbing gear with the belief that there is absolutely a good hold just a few moves above you (there probably is!).

17. If much of your body weight is hanging on your arms, you might not be placing your weight (center of mass) over your feet.

TIP: Invest more time practicing technique and body positioning. Focus on keeping your crotch and hips in near the wall (except on slabs) and experiment with moves where you turn one hip or the other to the wall. Some flexibility training may be beneficial, too (see chapter 4).

18. Intense soreness after only one day of cragging means that your training volume and intensity are not congruent with your outdoor climbing goals.

TIP: Step up your indoor training and always try for two solid training days during the workweek.

19. Do you have difficulty visualizing yourself successfully climbing the route? All peak performers acknowledge the importance of visualization.

TIP: Get into the habit of climbing each route in your mind's eye at least twice before giving it a real go. (See chapter 3.)

20. If you think you cannot reach key holds on difficult routes, you should be aware that this

is the oldest excuse in this sport. Funny thing is, some great short climbers never use this excuse! The reason—there is almost always a technical solution or intermediate hold to be discovered that will solve apparent reach problems.

TIP: Try a move five, ten, or even twenty different ways and you'll almost always find one that works!

21. If your feet cut loose and swing out on overhanging routes and roofs, it's possible that poor footwork and body positioning are responsible. More often, however, it results from weak core muscles (torso).

TIP: Perform the core-muscle exercises, described in chapter 7, at least thrice weekly. Also, spend more time in a bouldering cave working on your steep-wall footwork and body position.

22. If you get distracted by activity on the ground, remember that while climbing your focus must be locked onto the moves at hand, not directed downward. If less than 95 percent of your focus/attention is targeted on the climb, you don't have much chance of success.

TIP: Clear your mind of what's happening on the ground. If you need confirmation that your belayer is paying attention, a simple "watch me" will do, then refocus on the move at hand. (See chapter 3.)

23. It's common for beginning climbers to have difficulty reading sequences. Reading sequences comes from experience—each time you go climbing is money in the bank!

TIP: Climb up to four days a week to increase your rate of deposit. Always try to figure sequences from the ground and minimize use of beta (a real handicap to learning) except when climbing for performance.

24. Do you experience a deep flash pump on the first climb of the day? A flash pump results when you push your muscles too hard, too soon.

TIP: Lengthen your warm-up period, add more stretching and some sports massage, and always do a few increasingly difficult routes before attempting your project.

25. If you have more difficulty climbing when people are watching, remember that the pressure of needing to perform is entirely self-imposed. Therefore, it can be turned off as easily as you turn it on.

TIP: Commit to climb for yourself—for the challenge, adventure, and fun of it (all the reasons you got into climbing in the first place). Forget about the rest of the world, engage the process of climbing, and let the outcome take care of itself. (See chapter 3.)

26. If your feet unexpectedly pop off footholds, take heart that this is a common problem, even among some advanced climbers.

TIP: Refocus your attention on your feet for a few weeks. Evaluate whether you carefully place your feet on the best part of a hold or simply drop them onto the biggest-looking part. Also, do you hold your foot position stationary as you stand up or does your shoe move on the hold? These are things you need to practice in a nonperformance setting. (See chapter 4.)

27. Do you experience frequent elbow pain? There are two types of elbow tendinosis common to climbers. If you climb enough years, chances are you'll someday experience some elbow pain. Take heed!

TIP: Reverse wrist curls and forearm rotation exercises as well as regular forearm stretching and self-massage (or Armaid use) will help prevent these problems. Perform three sets of reverse wrist curls (twenty-five reps with a five- to fifteen-pound dumbbell) and two sets of forearm pronators, three days per week, year-round. Stretch both sides of your forearms each day. (See chapter 6.)

28. If you have trouble pushing yourself to the limit on a safe lead climb, your problem is more likely mental than physical. Keep in mind that mental fortitude is as important as brawn.

TIP: On safe routes consciously push yourself into the mental discomfort zone. At first this will feel like bitter medicine, but in time it will redefine your mental limits. (See chapter 3.)

29. If you have difficulty finding mid-route rest positions, you are missing one of the keys to sending routes near your limit.

TIP: Creative practice (in a nonperformance setting) at finding funky rest positions, modeling the rest positions of other climbers, and climbing experience at a wide range of crags will, in time, make finding “thank God” rests instinctual!

30. If your first attempt on a hard route is usually better than your second or third attempts that day, lack of muscular endurance and stamina are likely a contributing factor.

TIP: Climbing laps on training routes, doing twice-weekly threshold intervals, and generalized aerobic training will yield significant improve over the course of a few months. (See chapters 8 and 9.)